

POSC 3710: European Politics

8/31/2026: INTERWAR BREAKDOWN — HOW A DEMOCRACY DIES

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Where We Left Off

- Last time: democracy arrived slowly: expanded suffrage, fair elections, a government answerable to parliament
- Imperial Germany had near-universal male suffrage for a parliament that did not govern
- Britain's franchise was narrower, but the competition was real and conservatives could win it
- The Weimar constitution of 1919 finally assembled all the pieces
 - arguably the most democratic in Europe
- Today: how it collapsed, and why some democracies were more resilient

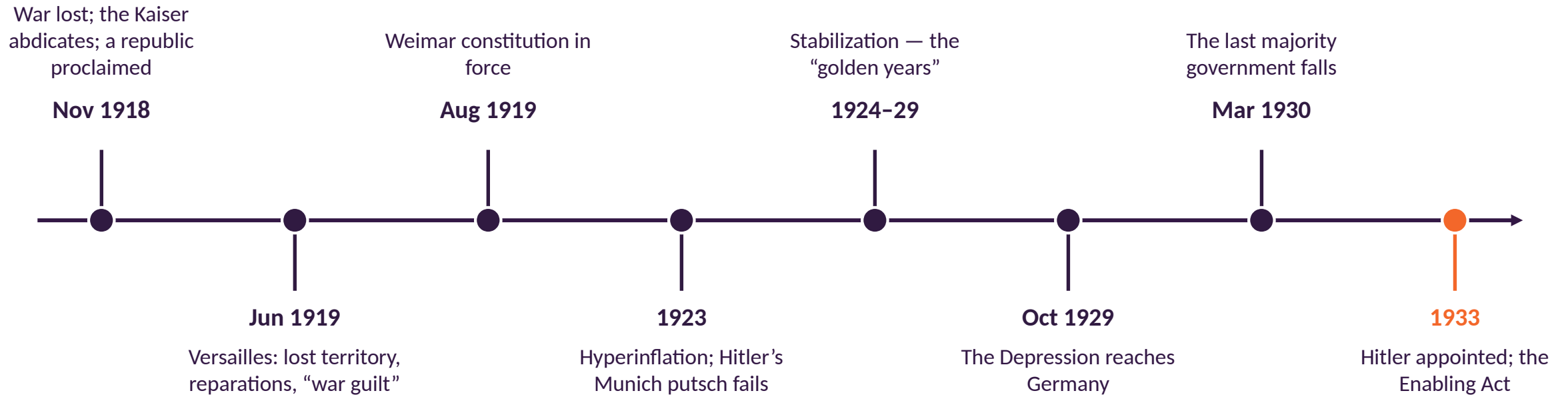
Why did German democracy die?

Each reading gives a different logic

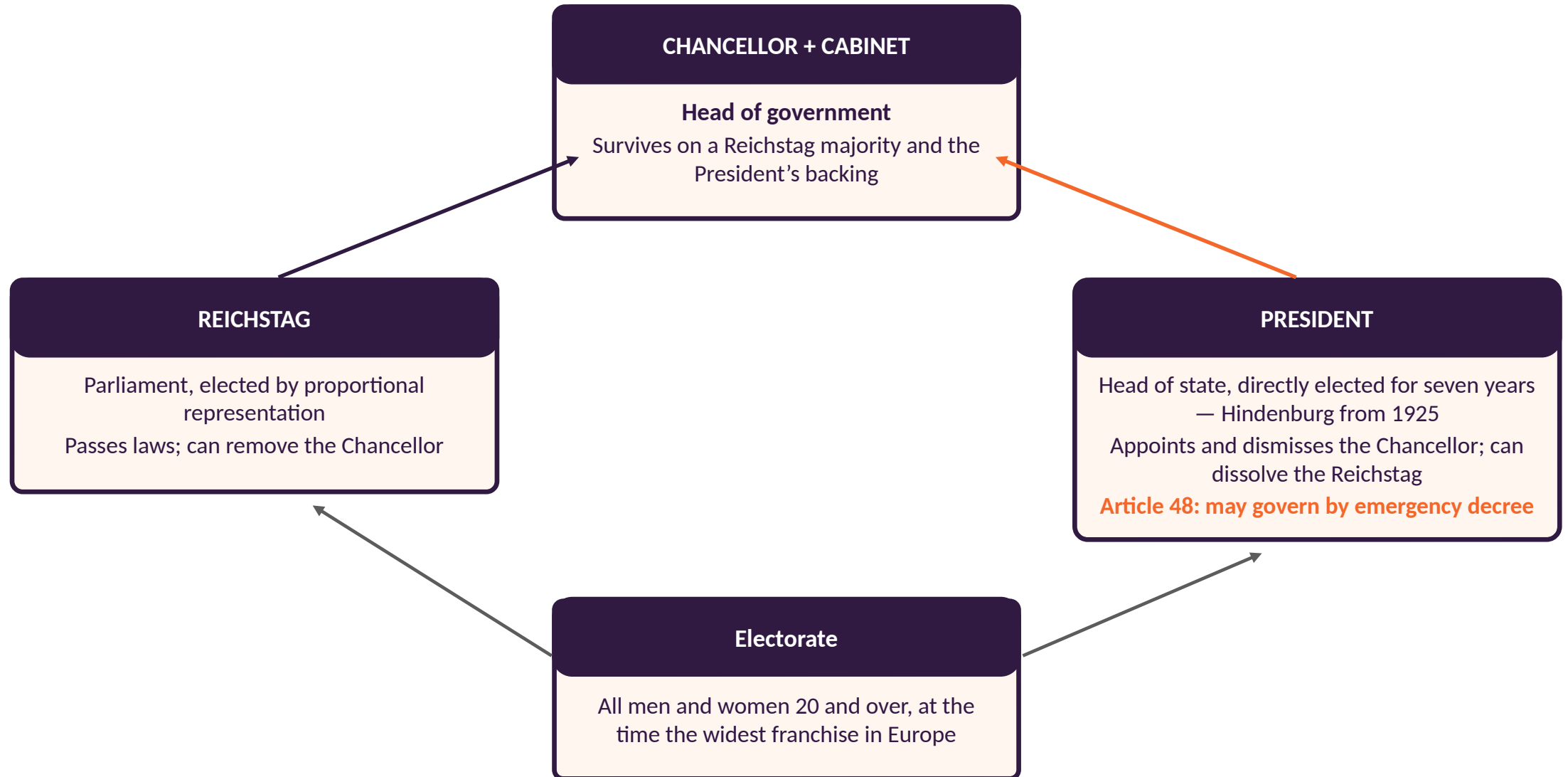
Or – they both could be missing key things

What are some potential explanations?

The German Post WWI Trajectory



How Weimar government worked



The parties

KPD	SPD	DDP	ZENTRUM	DVP	DNVP	NSDAP
Communists Anti-system left; the SPD as its main enemy 1928: 10.6% July 1932: 14.3%	Social Democrats Founded the republic, the left-leaning establishment 1928: 29.8% July 1932: 21.6%	Left liberals Drafted much of the constitution 1928: 4.8% July 1932: 1.0%	Catholic Centre In nearly every cabinet; 1928: 12.1% July 1932: 12.4%	Right liberals faded after 1929 1928: 8.7% July 1932: 1.2%	German Nationals Monarchist right; allied with Hitler 1928: 14.3% July 1932: 5.9%	National Socialists Anti-system right 1928: 2.6% July 1932: 37.3%

anti-system

the 1919 "Weimar Coalition" — 76% in January 1919, 44% by June 1920, never a majority again

anti-system

Vote shares: Reichstag elections of May 1928 and July 1932. Hindenburg belonged to no party; from March 1930 chancellors depended on his confidence rather than a Reichstag majority.

Were the National Socialists Socialists?

- The 1920 program's anti-capitalist planks targeted "Jewish finance capital," not property
- The wing that took the socialism seriously was expelled in 1930, murdered in 1934
- In power: unions abolished, strikes banned, the left destroyed first, industry re-privatized
- Came to power via an alliance with (and then betrayal of) traditional right/conservative forces
- They were not liberal/capitalist/market oriented, but of the right rather than socialist/Marxist

What is fascism?

“A form of political behavior marked by obsessive preoccupation with community decline, humiliation, or victimhood ... in which a mass-based party of committed nationalist militants, working in uneasy but effective collaboration with traditional elites, abandons democratic liberties and pursues with redemptive violence ... goals of internal cleansing and external expansion.”

— Robert Paxton, *The Anatomy of Fascism* (2004)

- A politics of national rebirth
 - the nation reborn by force after humiliation
- Against liberalism and against Marxism: the nation above the individual and above class
- Not a synonym for dictatorship: most interwar dictatorships were authoritarian, not fascist.
 - By 1944 Orwell was already complaining the word had become an all-purpose insult.

Italy Went First

- October 1922: the “March on Rome,” remembered as fascism seizing power
- In fact, King Victor Emmanuel III invited Mussolini to head the government
- The Fascists held 35 of 535 seats
- The establishment thought it could tame and use fascism; Mussolini governed until 1943

The Crisis Story Is Not Enough

- The usual explanation: Versailles, hyperinflation, the Depression, street violence
- The Depression also hit Britain, France, the Netherlands, and Sweden
 - None of them became a dictatorship
- Italy fell in 1922, before the Depression
- Crisis may be necessary, but it is not sufficient

Who broke, and who did not

DEMOCRATIC BEFORE 1918 Most survived

- Belgium, 1830
- United Kingdom, 1832
- Netherlands, 1848
- Switzerland, 1848
- France, 1870
- Norway, 1884
- Denmark, 1901
- Sweden, 1917

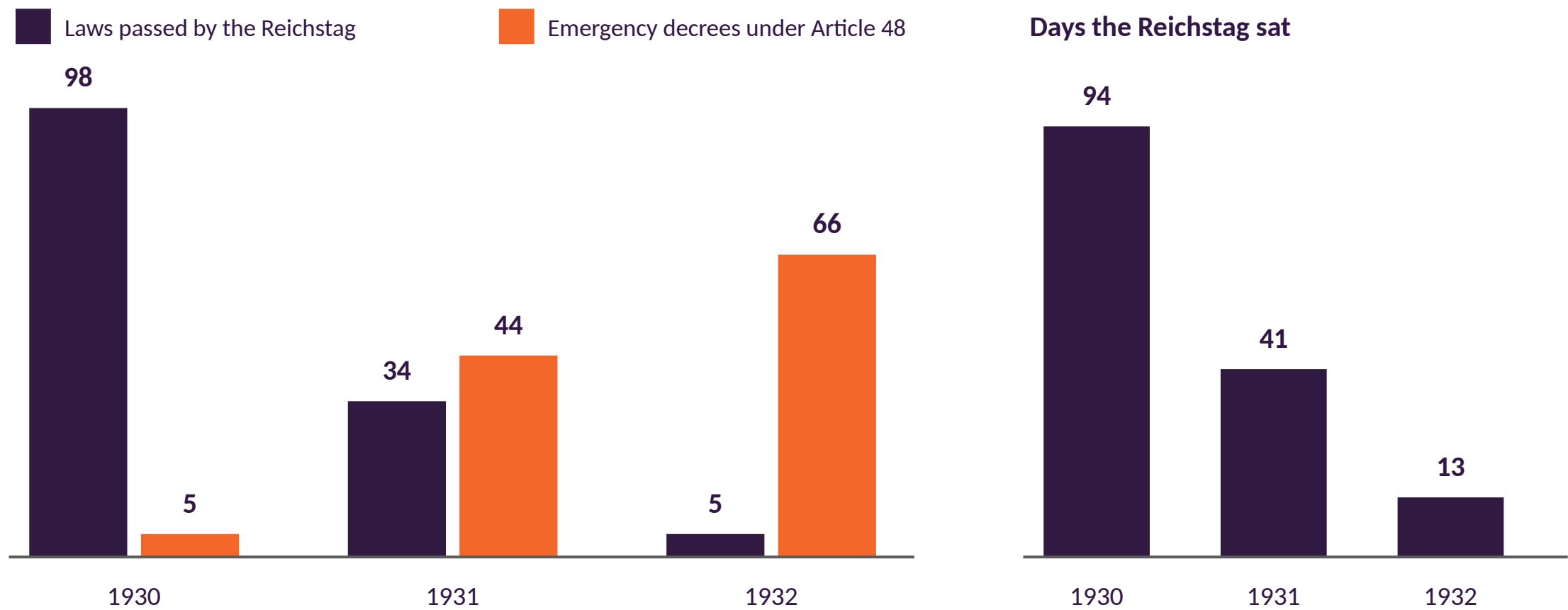
DEMOCRATIC ONLY AFTER 1918 almost none survived

“In a broad arc from Lisbon to Tallinn, all democracies save that of Czechoslovakia broke down, some in the 1920s, others in the 1930s.”

Jørgen Møller, 2018

Dates are continuous democracy, excepting wartime occupations. Italy and Spain held elections before 1918; most authors code them as lacking genuine competition for power.

Parliament stopped governing before Hitler took office

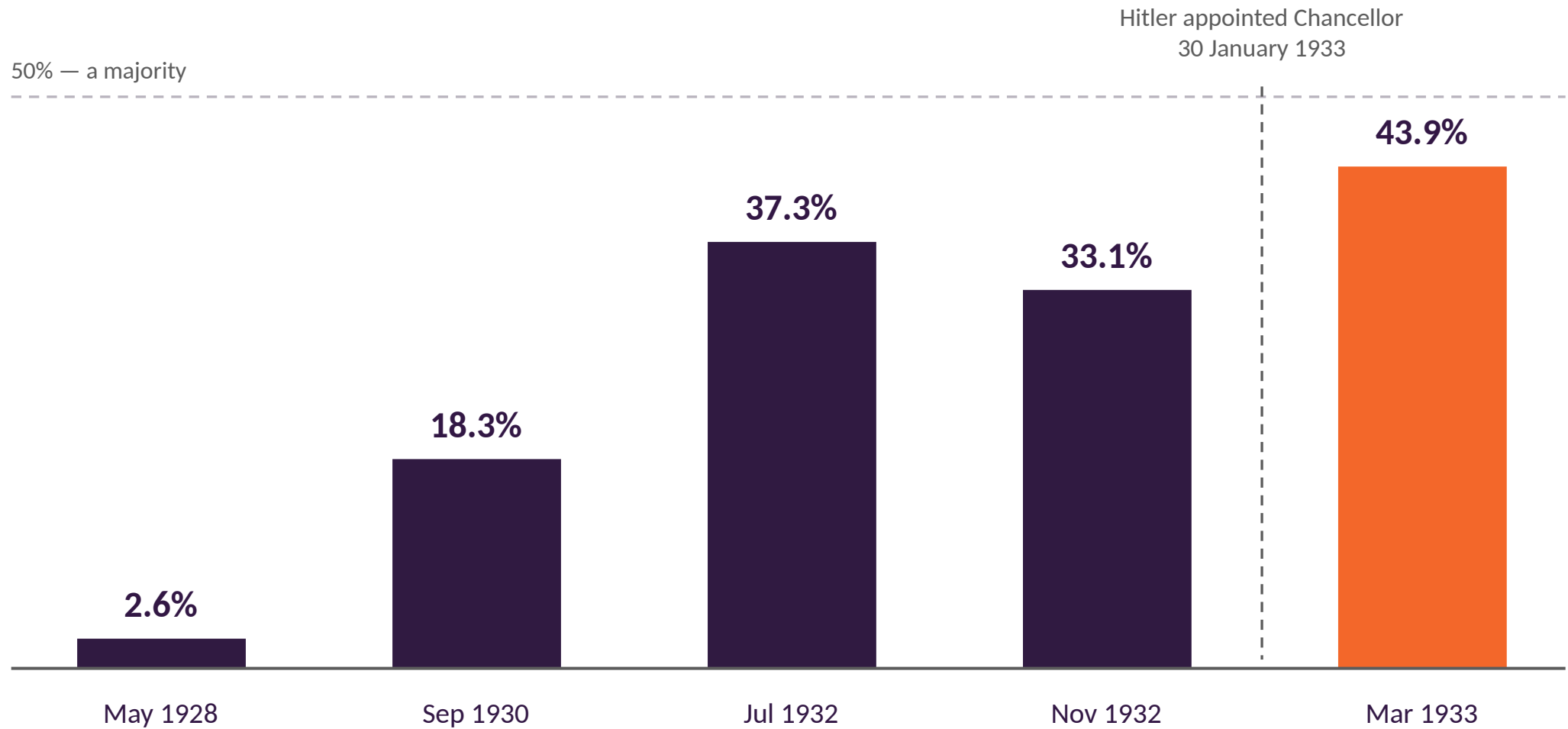


Data from Bracher (1980)

Government by Decree

- From March 1930, no government held a Reichstag majority
- Brüning, then Papen, then Schleicher, a series of chancellors chosen by Hindenburg, not by parliament
- Article 48, written for emergencies, became the normal way to govern
- Hindenburg, not the electorate, decided who governed Germany

The Nazi vote never reached a majority



The fateful alliance, January 1933

“We’ve engaged him for ourselves.... Within two months, we will have pushed [him] so far into a corner that he’ll squeal.”

— Franz von Papen, architect of the deal, 30 January 1933

- The Nazi vote had just fallen; the conservatives had no majority for anything
- Hitler was appointed Chancellor with only two other Nazis in the cabinet
- Papen and his circle expected office to be able to manage him

Later: “I have just committed the greatest stupidity of my life; I have allied myself with the greatest demagogue in world history.”

A constitutional republic dismantled by constitutional means



What Made It Legal

- Nothing required a coup
- Article 48 supplied the decrees
- The Enabling Act let the cabinet legislate alone
- It passed 444 to 94
 - KPD deputies arrested, 26 SPD deputies in custody, hiding, or dead
- The vote was taken in the Kroll Opera House, with SA men inside the chamber

The warning signs were public the whole time

REJECTS THE RULES

A weak commitment to the democratic rules of the game

- 1923: an armed putsch in Munich
- Nine months in prison; then the "path of legality"

DENIES LEGITIMACY

Rivals cast as criminals and traitors, not opponents

- The republic's founders: "November criminals"

TOLERATES VIOLENCE

Political violence excused, encouraged, organized

- The SA — a uniformed party army in the streets

CURTAILS LIBERTIES

Openly ready to strip opponents' rights

- The program had been in print since 1925

Inspired by Levitsky and Ziblatt's test, building on Juan Linz.

Civil Society Cuts Both Ways

- The textbook view since Putnam: choirs, clubs and associations make democracy work
- Weimar Germany had one of the densest associational landscapes in Europe
- Those same networks handed the NSDAP trained organizers and ready-made audiences
- Berman: the weakness was in political institutions, not in civic life
- Where parties and institutions are weak, associational life organizes against the system, not for it

Militant Democracy

- Karl Loewenstein, watching from exile, coined the term in 1937
- Militant democracy: legal limits on expression and participation, imposed to protect democracy itself
- Party bans, speech restrictions, loyalty tests, emergency powers
- Can a democracy defend itself by restricting democratic rights?
- Some interwar democracies used these tools, fought back, and survived

Where the gatekeepers held

FINLAND

- The Lapua Movement: over a thousand Social Democrats abducted, a march on Helsinki, a failed coup
- Conservatives broke with their former ally and joined the left in a "Lawfulness Front"
- President Svinhufvud, once Lapua's favorite, banned the movement

BELGIUM

- 1936: Rex and the Flemish-nationalist VNV take nearly a fifth of the vote between them
- Degrelle's Rex, financed by Hitler and Mussolini, pushed for a "March on Brussels"
- The Catholic Party expelled Rexist sympathizers, allied with Liberals and Socialists, and crushed Degrelle in a 1937 by-election

Both cases appear in Levitsky & Ziblatt + Capoccia.

Strategies to Protect Democracy

PARTY BANS

Outlaw the anti-system party

THE RISK

- A ban needs a court, and courts can be captured
- The banned party's voters do not disappear
- Whoever holds power draws the line

SPEECH AND ASSEMBLY

Limit what extremists may say

THE RISK

- "Extremist" is defined by the government of the day
- Restriction supplies the grievance it means to contain
- Enforcement is uneven, and visibly so

EMERGENCY POWERS

Arm the executive for a crisis

THE RISK

- Article 48 was written as a defensive clause
- It became the instrument of the takeover
- Powers granted for an emergency outlive it

All three are in use in Europe today. Germany has banned parties; several states restrict extremist speech; nearly every constitution here has an emergency clause.

Discussion

- Could any of the strategies to protect democracy have worked in the 1930s?
- Are they compatible with liberal democracy?